

VOTERS AWAIT VERDICT

EVEN AS ELECTIONS IN THREE KEY STATES DRAW NEAR, THE ECI'S ELECTORAL ROLL REVISION LEAVES MILLIONS IN LIMBO AS THEIR CASES FALL 'UNDER ADJUDICATION'

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**

ON FEBRUARY 28, WEST BENGAL'S REVISED ELECTORAL ROLL was published after four bruising months of the Election Commission of India's (ECI) Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise. Chief electoral officer (CEO) Manoj Kumar Agarwal pegged the post-SIR electorate at 70.46 million, down 8.06 per cent from 76.64 million before the exercise began, after 6.18 million deletions (see *The Great Purge*). But the real headline was the asterisk: another 6 million electors were listed as 'under adjudication', their voting rights put on hold until judicial officers decide their fate.

Under electoral rules, a state's voter roll is frozen 10 days before the last date for filing nominations in Lok Sabha or assembly elections. This means only those voters whose 'under adjudication' or 'doubtful' cases are resolved before the prescribed deadline will be eligible to vote in the upcoming West Bengal assembly polls. How quickly the judicial officers—630 appointed till the last count—can dispose of the cases will determine the final electoral landscape.

The West Bengal SIR became nationally distinctive for its scale and architecture. It also marked a critical milestone because its final roll was issued under Supreme Court supervision, just weeks before the end of the assembly's term. The voters 'under adjudication' were primarily flagged by the ECI software for 'logical discrepancies' or for being 'unmapped' to legacy electoral rolls from 2002. After the draft roll, the administration issued notices for 'logical discrepancies' to about 13.6 million voters and served summons to nearly 3.2 million 'unmapped' voters. Logical discrepancies included data anomalies such as spelling variations, age/relationship mismatches and other inconsistencies that can arise from old digitisation errors, migration or life events, including women changing residence/ surnames after marriage. The 'unmapped' tag flowed from the SIR's insistence on tracing entries to legacy intensive-revision rolls (2002-04). The eventual numbers came down to just over 6 million on February 28.

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THE LEGAL WAR

Earlier, chief minister Mamata Banerjee had rushed to the Supreme Court, accusing the EC of 'targeting' Bengal and using the exercise to delete genuine voters, especially women and minorities. She pointed to Muslim-majority districts such as Murshidabad (1.1 million cases) and Malda (nearly 828,000) carrying the heaviest 'logical discrepancy' load. She alleged that the ECI's deployment of over 8,000 'micro-observers'—largely drawn from BJP-ruled states, who were given veto power over the state's statutory electoral registration officers (EROs)—was a politically motivated purge. In her own Bhabanipur constituency, she pointed out, over 47,000 voters were scrubbed from the rolls. She also argued that the SIR's methods were drifting into a de facto citizenship/ identity sieve executed through rigid document expectations and algorithmic flags. The ECI claimed that micro-observers had been deployed only because the state failed to provide enough staff.

On March 5, Mamata carried the battle into the BJP's camp, accusing the Centre of orchestrating the deletion of thousands of voters from the Matua community—traditionally considered a BJP support base. "It's